Taberg Girls & Their Journey

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A composite account built entirely from documented case files — federal court monitoring reports and the 2026 federal opinion in D.B. v. Montana — so it is true in every detail, though no single girl's file contains all of it. Where details are blended, it is noted.

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The Long Way to Taberg

Before: the home. She grows up in a borough of New York City — say, the Bronx or Brooklyn — in a household where violence is the weather. Maybe her mother's boyfriend hits her mother. Maybe someone in the house — a stepfather, an uncle — sexually abuses her, and when she tells, the adults around her soften it into a euphemism. Her mother is overwhelmed, addicted, or gone. What every documented Taberg girl's file shares is this: *the trouble starts at home, years before the first arrest.* Her "behavioral problems" — running away, lying, fighting at school, cutting herself — begin exactly when the abuse begins. The monitors noticed this so consistently that they flagged it in writing: one girl's file recorded that her problems *started around the time she reported being raped*.

The removal. The city takes custody through ACS or a county DSS. She's five, or eight, or ten. What follows is not one placement but a *relay* — grandmother first, then a relative, then a stranger's home. One documented girl's timeline: placed with a grandmother at five, moved to a relative who abused and neglected her, into foster care at ten. By the time she's a teenager she has had two, three, four homes. Each move is logged; each move also teaches her the lesson that nothing is permanent and adults leave.

The first facility. Foster homes can't manage a traumatized teenager who runs, who fights, who cuts. So the system

escalates: residential treatment placement — a group home or therapeutic residence. She's fourteen or fifteen. This is where the documented histories show the system making its core mistake: the behaviors that got her here — running away, "ungovernability," truancy, stealing small things — are trauma symptoms, but they're processed as delinquency. She runs from the placement. In the files, the phrase is always passive: "*she was sent to detention by DSS.*" Nobody in this chain has anywhere else to send her.

The arrest. What she's actually charged with is almost always small. The monitors catalogued the real offenses of a real Taberg cohort: **criminal mischief** (5 girls), possession of stolen property, assault, petit larceny, trespassing, resisting arrest, probation violation. One sixteen-year-old with fetal alcohol spectrum disorder — low verbal comprehension, executive function deficits, a face marked by the prenatal alcohol — was sent upstate for *stealing $7.56 of candy and juice from a grocery store playroom*.

Family court. The judge doesn't see a rape survivor with a psychiatric chart; the judge sees a probation violation. She's adjudicated a "juvenile delinquent" — or, in the older files, PINS, "person in need of supervision," a category that criminalized runaway behavior outright. The court commits her to the custody of the Office of Children and Family Services. And here is the bottleneck that defines the girls' system: if a girl needs structure beyond a non-secure group setting, there is exactly one secure door left in the entire state. So a child from the Bronx — or the 15-year-old with developmental disabilities

functioning "like a five-year-old," rejected by every voluntary agency in and out of state for being too aggressive — is sent 250 miles upstate to a former boys' school in a former iron-mining hamlet, because the one thing the state won't do is refuse the intake.

Arrival. Strip intake. Inventory of her possessions. A medical screen. Within days, a psychiatrist's evaluation — and because the pipeline selects for the most psychiatrically damaged girls, the odds are overwhelming she's medicated quickly. In one documented cohort of eighteen: all but two had psychiatric diagnoses; sixteen were on psychotropics; eight on two or more — Seroquel, Abilify, Zoloft, Depakote, and in one case Clozapine, a drug of last resort for treatment-resistant psychosis.

She's assigned to a unit — maybe the mental health unit, eleven beds, the only one for girls in New York — and to a "support team": a clinician, a nurse, youth division aides, a teacher who comes over from the Annex school. The plan on paper is treatment. The reality, documented month by month: **one-third of clinical positions unfilled for four straight months** — three clinicians for seventeen to twenty-two actively suicidal, medicated, traumatized teenage girls.

Daily life. Wake, meds line, school in the Annex, programming in the building, TRIAD groups, individual therapy — maybe four sessions in a good month. The staff, rural Oneida County workers hired off the closing of the boys' facility down the road, are exhausted; in their own words to federal monitors: *burned out, stretched too thin,* "*there is no cavalry coming.*" The girls sense it — four out of five reported to monitors that they

had been assaulted or threatened.

The crisis loop. She cuts. Or she bolts for the door, or spits, or throws a chair. The response, in a building with no clinical staff to respond, is physical: **a restraint**. The numbers from one documented year at this facility: 746 restraints projected annually for a population of about twenty — and the monitors' video review found five girls restrained in a single event packet, facedown holds lasting 52 and 53 minutes against a 9.9-minute standard. Between 75 and 89 percent of restraints each month were staff pulling sharp objects out of girls who were trying to hurt themselves. Suicide watches ran 8 to 28 per month. In March 2015, four girls absorbed 40 of the facility's 68 restraints. This is the part of the story the monitors kept returning to: the restraint system *was* the mental health system.

The other thing that can happen. This is where the 2026 federal case lives. A male Youth Division Aide — uniform, handcuffs, radio, flashlight — notices a girl with no family visiting, no cavalry coming. The amended complaint in *D.B. v. Montana* describes the pattern: grooming first, using the power of the uniform, then sexual abuse. One plaintiff, C.P., was thirteen when she arrived in January 2014 and stayed until October 2018 — her entire adolescence, ages 13 to 17, inside. The abuse is alleged to have left rug burns. The survivors' accounts say they didn't report because who would believe a "delinquent" against a state employee — and because the site director, Sussana Tillino, was responsible for supervising exactly those staff.

Discharge — the "assurances." Her stay ends — average around five months, though documented stays ran from 19 days to 460 days. Where she goes next is decided by whoever will take her: often back to the same home where the abuse occurred, on a parent's *assurance* that the abuser has moved out — the documented case: a fifteen-year-old rape survivor released home on her mother's word, her discharge plan softening her own rape into "*it is alleged that…*" If she destabilizes — and she usually does — she cycles back. The returnee rate hit 41% in one documented cohort; seven of seventeen girls had already been through Taberg before. The monitors called it unacceptable. The system called it Tuesday.

The end of the story, as the state measures it: statewide, 45% of girls released from OCFS custody were rearrested within three years. The ones who escape the statistics do it the way the monitors' best-case file described — a girl whose incarcerated brother visited, whose father fought for phone calls into her treatment meetings, who named her own survival plan: "*Not to use. I ran away from problems. Drugs made me not think about anything.*"

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That is the whole machine, start to finish: trauma in, handcuffs in between, statistics out — run at roughly **$900,000 per child per year** in the secure system, in a facility the federal government has been monitoring for a decade and a half, where the most common conviction among the girls it holds is criminal mischief.